INC-2026-01-09: Scores each authorisation attempt for fraud risk within 40ms degradation

Northwind Payments · SEV2 · service fraud-scorer · author l.mwangi

Started 2026-01-09T13:00:00Z · detected 2026-01-09T13:11:00Z · resolved 2026-01-09T13:13:00Z

Customer impact

Fraud scoring was effectively disabled for 2 hours 14 minutes. No fraudulent transactions were confirmed in the window, but 340 payments were later manually reviewed.

Root cause

A model artefact was published without its feature schema, so every scoring request fell back to the default risk score of 0.5.

Causing change

This incident was caused by release fraud-3.8.0, deployed to fraud-scorer. The release is recorded in the change log.

Affected services

fraud-scorer, payment-gateway. Downstream services were affected through their dependency on fraud-scorer.

Timeline (UTC)

13:00 — Release fraud-3.8.0 completed rollout earlier in the day.

13:00 — First symptoms observed on fraud-scorer.

13:11 — Alert pages the on-call engineer for fraud-scorer.

13:32 — Cause identified and mitigation begins.

13:13 — Service returns to baseline; incident resolved.

Action items

• Add a pre-deploy validation check for fraud-scorer.

• Require a load test for configuration changes of this class.

• Add an integration test covering the failure mode.